STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 18 · If There Is No Wife Yet

Transcript · Wes Hart

Good to see you. Come on and sit. Uh, a man near the back patted the chair before he trusted it. It held. They usually do. Uh, if we haven't met, I'm Wes. Glad you took a seat. Some of you know this room. Some of you, uh, found it today, and you're still deciding. Deciding counts. You stayed. Last time we said purpose is not a mood you wait on. It's a work you carry in the place you're already standing. I mean, the place. The people. The hours already in your hands. Keep that. Today that place gets a name. Some of you are doing the days and calling them a warm-up. The real part, you figure, starts when a woman says yes. Some of you heard yes a long time ago. She's in the house. You know the order of her morning. You still don't know her. Same trouble. A man standing beside his own life and calling the gap close enough. I have— I have done both. Before there was a wife in my house, I treated the days like a hallway. After there was, I learned her shortcuts and missed her. So let me say the thing plain, and then we'll walk it. If there is no wife yet, you are not waiting to start. You are a man with a garden, and it needs working today. If she is already beside you, standing near her will not know her. You study her. You write it down. A ring is a gift. It is not the moment you become a man. And a shared roof is not a study. Bring the man you are. Stay with that. Both halves are for this room. Uh, the single man stays for all of it. The husband stays for all of it. Nobody here is sitting out.

Uh, these marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in this room. I'm not gonna build all four from the ground up. Today they have to land on two refusals I know from the inside. Uh, the first is a man who will not live until somebody else arrives. The second is a man who stopped learning the woman already there. Stop waiting. Uh, passivity can sound holy. A man says he is waiting on God while the day in front of him already has his name on it. That includes the hover. The almost-ask. The life you keep calling temporary. It also includes a husband who quit asking because he thinks he already finished. Pick up the weight. The place is yours. The knowledge is yours. You don't get to blame a missing ring for a garden you would not touch. And you don't get to blame her quiet if you filled every quiet with a fix. Go first. Courage is not volume. I mean, it is speaking up when your voice would rather stay vague. Courage here is a plain ask, or a clean release. Courage is also the question you have been walking around in your own kitchen. And the pay. God's pay. Not the feeling that life finally started because a woman said yes. Not the comfort of saying you know her pretty well. I have— I have wanted both of those prizes. They pay fast. They do not keep. The marks are how a man walks in the life he has already been given.

Uh, let me put a verse under that. First Corinthians seven, verse seventeen. This is the NIV. Nevertheless, each person should live as a believer in whatever situation the Lord has assigned to them, just as God has called them. This is the rule I lay down in all the churches. Assigned. Called. Live in it. I mean, today. Not when the place looks like the one you keep picturing. Uh, the situation you are in is not a dress rehearsal for a better one. It is the ground with your name on the gate. If there is no wife yet, that is an assignment, not a pause. A wife, if the Lord gives you one, walks into work you have already begun. Hear this other line. Proverbs nineteen, verse fourteen. Houses and wealth are inherited from parents, but a prudent wife is from the Lord. From the Lord. A gift. Not a promotion into manhood. You don't— you don't level up on the day of a vow. You bring a man to the vow, or you bring a boy in a good shirt. Uh, I ate standing up for a long stretch in a place that was already mine. Over the sink. Like a chair might make it official. The chair was never the holdup. I was. I called the place temporary so I would not have to keep it. How many of you have said some version of, when life starts, then I'll live like a man? Hand up. I'm not collecting names. Yeah. I figured. Uh, that sentence can wear a nice coat. It can sound patient. It can sound humble. Under it is a man refusing the days he has. The garden does not wait until somebody else moves in. Weeds don't check your status. They just take the ground you leave.

Uh, single is not one man. There are three, and they are not having the same year. Uh, stay with me on this. If you're married, don't drift. Uh, you'll need the second half, and you need to hear these men as brothers, not as a preface. The first man has never married. You may ache for a wife. You may be half in. You may— you may have quit looking. With nobody real in the picture, uh, you can invent a woman no living woman can match. If you're young, hear this without a sneer in it. A girlfriend is not the stamp. She does not make you a man by standing next to you. These years are already the work. A place you inhabit. Money you can explain. A brother. A clean conscience. That is most of a husband's weight. The wife is the part still missing. The second man, the marriage ended. You are not waiting on something you never had. You are grieving what you lost, or what you broke, or both. Maybe between two houses. Maybe a church that goes clumsy when you walk in. Something died. If you will not name it, you will stack the next thing on a silence, and the silence will crack it. Say your part. I did this. Leave her piece off the end of the sentence. Your children come before any new woman. Stay among the men even if it's awkward. Do not sprint at another marriage to make the pain sit down. The third man buried his wife. You lived the life, and then the house went quiet in a way the younger men cannot picture. Uh, people go short on words. I won't. Stay in the work. Stay with us. Her last day was not the end of your assignment.

So what does a man build when his is the only name on the place. Uh, he makes a home he actually inhabits. Not a storage unit he sleeps in. A floor you can see. A meal you cooked. Bills that don't scare you when they show up. Uh, I have opened my own fridge and been greeted by hot sauce and a mystery. That is not a home. That is a man hiding from his own kitchen. Set a

table. Feeding people did not arrive with a ring. Cook for one more man than you planned on. A younger one who is drifting. An older one the room has gotten used to overlooking. Leave the place better than you found it. Get men around you. You need— you need them. A quiet place will not notice the stretch where you vanish. Find one man ahead of you. Do not hand your drift a long runway. Give the Lord the hours this stretch actually holds. A house full of little kids cannot spend an evening the way you can. If you burn those hours on waiting, you spent the one advantage this assignment gave you. Father somebody. There are boys around your church who are short a man. You have the afternoon. Sit with one while he does a hard thing. Show him how to keep a word he gave. The shape of fathering can change. The work does not. And keep yourself clean. The marriage bed is a covenant, and the keeping starts before there is a wife to share it. Your eyes and your hands are either storing something for that covenant or spending it early. First Timothy five, verse two. Treat younger women as sisters, with absolute purity. That covers every woman outside a covenant with you. Including the one you hope might enter one.

Uh, most of you want a wife. Good. Uh, the want is not the problem. Find is a moving word. I mean, look at what will still be true when the face changes. Does she fear the Lord. Does she tell the truth. Is she kind when nobody is clapping. Attraction is real. Weigh it last, after those. Then ask in the open. A named evening. A reason she can hear. Uh, a long fog of almost-plans is a stall. So is a string of messages that never becomes a time and a place. She can tell a man moving toward her from a man who wants the feeling and not the risk. I called— I called it careful. There was a woman, before my wife, and I stayed vague on purpose. I never named an evening. I never said what I wanted. She finally asked if I was ever going to. I felt caught. I had been passive, and I had given it a gentle voice. Then decide. A few days is too fast for a life. A long stretch with no decision spends years that are hers. If you know her character and you are still circling, the true name for that is passive. A real man rejects that. He walks toward a covenant, or he sets her free in a way that leaves her dignity whole. Let an older man meet her. How she is with her father, and with her friends, will tell you the truth a good evening can hide. Keep your hands off her. Sex before the covenant clouds your judgment, and it trains both of you to treat the vow as optional. Uh, I have sat with men who crossed that line early. They don't brag about it. Marry when you can carry the weight. A feeling called ready will not carry it. You need work you can explain, a home, brothers, a kept body, and a Father you talk to. If those are in place, and she fears God, and the older men say go, then go. Pick it up.

Uh, let me tell you about a man named Nolan. I have known him a long time. Never married. Good worker. Uh, he rented a small place with a strip of dirt out back. You know, he called it the someday patch. When he had a wife, he said, they would decide what went in it. So he mowed around it. Weeds took the middle. The shovel in the shed had never touched dirt. Uh, I stood out there with him one afternoon. I told him the weeds were not waiting on a wedding. He did not enjoy that. Uh, an older man in our group had been after him. Quit living like a visitor on ground that already has your name. Nolan went quiet. That same afternoon he turned the soil. A

neighbor had two tomato starts he was gonna toss. Nolan put them in. Then he put two chairs on the step and had men over. A young man with empty afternoons took one of them. Nolan asked how the day had gone. The part that stayed with me came after. He has a sister. They talked weather. They talked their mother's appointments. Uh, he asked her one real question. What's been heavy, and don't give me the short one. She started. He almost— he almost explained her life back to her. He caught it. Hands on his knees. He waited. She said she was scared she was the only one noticing their mother getting smaller. He told me later he had known her his whole life and had never asked. He said, I thought a wife would walk me into my life. She would have walked in on a man still saving a bare patch for a day he was already standing in. The plants did not get him married. They got him present. And his sister showed him he did not yet know how to hear a woman. He started there, before there was a wife to fail.

Now the other half. Uh, you can share a house and not know the woman in it. Proximity is not knowledge. Uh, I knew a husband named Mitch. Good man. Uh, he could tell you the order of the morning, her coat on the third hook, the sigh she made at the mail. He thought the sigh was the woman. One evening she said, you haven't asked me anything you don't already have an answer for. He sat on that. He asked what she was afraid of in that season. The first answer was ordinary. School stuff. A schedule. He almost— he almost nodded and went to fix a meeting. He stayed. The next thing she said was that she was afraid he had decided who she was a long time ago, and he liked that woman better. He wrote it on a scrap in the truck. He kept the scrap. He told me it scared him, how much of his knowing was memory of a younger wife. That is the work in front of a lot of you. Proverbs twenty, verse five. The purposes of a person's heart are deep waters, but one who has insight draws them out. Deep waters. The deep thing does not volunteer. You draw it up. That work belongs to the husband. It costs attention. It costs time. It costs a decision that she is worth knowing past what you already decided. First Peter three, verse seven. Husbands, in the same way be considerate as you live with your wives, and treat them with respect as the weaker partner and as heirs with you of the gracious gift of life, so that nothing will hinder your prayers. Live with her according to knowledge. Respect. Heirs together. And the line a lot of us skip. Your prayers sit in the same room as your knowledge of her. Neglect the one, and the other goes thin.

Uh, so what is there to know. Uh, learn her story. How she was fathered, and what that taught her about men. What happened before you that she has never told all the way. I mean, learn the fears she actually has. Ask what frightens her most right now, then stay quiet. Learn what fills her and what empties her. Uh, a full room wakes one woman up and wrings another out. Learn how love lands on her. A lot of us give the kind we would want back. Doing. Fixing. Handling it. Some wives receive that. Some need words. Some need an hour with no job in it. Some need a touch that is not on its way to the bedroom. Ask her— ask her when she has felt most loved by you. Then do that again. Learn her body without getting cute about it. Her cycle, so you carry more in the stretch she has less. A pregnancy. The long haul after a birth. The changes that

come later, that a husband can sail past. Learn her walk with God. How she prays. What she is wrestling. The promise she is standing on. Then you can pray a real need instead of a prayer that could fit anybody. I could tell you the score of a game I didn't care about, and not what my wife was asking God for. I spent the attention where a crowd would notice. Learn the ordinary day. You know, the middle of the afternoon. The kids. The hard hour of her work. A man who has never asked will say a sentence that lands wrong and then blame the quiet. Learn her people. Her friends. Her mother. What those ties cost. Learn what she still wants, what she set down, what she quit saying because nobody asked. Look for a way to hand one back. She will trust a man who does.

Uh, how a man learns her is plainer than we make it. Ask, then wait. Most of us ask and start building the reply before she finishes the first sentence. When she goes quiet, she is often not done. The real sentence usually shows up one breath later. You know, I showed up once with a whole plan. She had shown up with a sentence. I was early to the wrong meeting. Uh, she did not need my columns. She needed a husband who could stay in the chair. Hear her before you repair anything. Your body will want a solution. Hold it. Tell her you're still in it, and ask for the rest. Fix her every time and she will stop bringing you the real thing. Stay with her, and she may trust you with the rest. Write the small things. Uh, I wrote notes about my work for years. Parts. Dates. What a man needed from me. I would not— I would not write one line about my wife, because it felt odd, like I was turning her into a task. Then I missed something she had told me once, about her father's appointment, and the odd thing was that I had forgotten. I started a card. One line. I still miss things. I miss fewer. Ask her what you get wrong. Skip the defense. If a baby is new in the house, uh, the woman across from you is under a weight you cannot see. Ask what she needs before the next hour, not the next year. Notice if she has eaten, been outside, laughed. If she pulls back from touch, believe the load. Watch for a darkness that is more than tired. It has a name. It is common. A doctor can help. If she is not herself for a long stretch, or she says things about herself that scare you, go with her. That is a man who knows his wife and keeps her.

Uh, let me walk the room before I send you to the tables. If the marriage ended, and the truth is you did not know her, put that inside the sentence I did this. Uh, you still have to know their mother well enough to parent without a war. Uh, what she fears for the kids. What sets it off. What calms it. If God gives you another wife, start knowing her while the days are still new. If she died, grieve out loud, for as long as it takes. Keep a hand on the work, one brother, and a seat in this room. A widower can call the slow fade rest. It is drift with a soft voice. Whether you marry again sits with you, with God, with your grown children, and with her, if there is a her. Some men do. Some never do. The years can still be full. If I say yet, and that is your chair, yet is not a taunt. I am not waving a life you lost over your head. I am saying the life still in your hands is a real assignment. If you never married, and the years have stacked up, you are not the mascot in here. A long obedience is not the same as being current. You can be faithful and still

be saving a bare patch. If you're single, this page is yours. Ask your mother or your sister one real question, and wait for the whole answer. No fixing. No flirting. A man who can hear a sister can learn how to hear a wife. If the work is going well, look again. A beautiful place can still be a place you only sleep in. And if you're married, she already knows whether you are a student or a visitor. You can feel that, right? She knew before I said it.

If there is no wife yet, you are not waiting to start. You are a man with a garden, and it needs working today. And proximity is not knowledge. Study her. Write it down. I hope you— I hope you leave here done treating your life like a hallway, and done calling a guess a marriage. Uh, in a minute you sit at the tables and work this part together. Which of the three men are you, and have you been living as though life has not started? Never married. Single again because it ended. Single again because she died. If you're married, say so, and still name whether the knowing ever really started. What area do you know least about your wife? Name the thin place. If you're single, what would a sister practice expose? And what will you build, or what will you ask? If you have never married, pick one build and do it. If you are single again, pick one, and tell God one true sentence about the grief and one about your part. If you are married, ask one question from the thin place, hear the whole answer, write it down, and start the page. Uh, tell a brother which man you are and which thing you picked. If you're divorced and thinking about dating, tell him that, and ask whether you are ready. If you're married, tell him what you found out that you did not know. Do not let either of you say I know her pretty well. How many of you already had that sentence ready on the way in? Hand up. Keep it honest. Alright. That one stays retired. You've carried the marks through this room. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Tables. Open the workbook. Do this part together.